

**ACTIVITY 15 — LEARNER WORKSHEET****PR Crisis Response Plan**

| TYPE      | DURATION   | MAPS TO | TOPIC                        |
|-----------|------------|---------|------------------------------|
| Role Play | 25 minutes | LU4     | LU4 — Branding Effectiveness |

|             |  |
|-------------|--|
| <b>Name</b> |  |
| <b>Date</b> |  |

**What you are doing**

It's 9pm, the night before the founder's biggest relaunch media interview yet. A customer posts a video of her new Nimbus jar — from the new sustainable packaging line launched with the anniversary campaign — cracked and leaking product, captioned "the 'eco-friendly' packaging Nimbus is so proud of." Within two hours it has hundreds of shares and a wave of other customers replying with their own photos.

**What you will produce:** A same-night crisis-response script — public holding statement plus next-day interview line — rehearsed and benchmarked against a real crisis example.

**The scenario**

Operations thinks it may be a single bad batch from the new packaging supplier, but can't confirm numbers until morning. The journalist doing tomorrow's interview has already seen the thread and has emailed asking whether Nimbus knew about a defect before launch.

The founder wants to say nothing until Operations has the full facts — but the thread is growing every hour, and tomorrow's interview is unavoidable. Your group must decide what Nimbus does tonight, and what the spokesperson says tomorrow morning.

**Role assignment**

| Role                 | Played by | Goal                                                                  |
|----------------------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Spokesperson         |           | Represent Nimbus publicly without over-promising                      |
| Journalist           |           | Get a real, on-record answer for tomorrow's story                     |
| Crisis-Response Lead |           | Coordinate the facts and the fix before Nimbus says anything publicly |

**Your steps**

1. **Assign the three roles** — Spokesperson, Journalist, Crisis-Response Lead. The Journalist must genuinely press — a soft interview teaches nothing.

2. **Separate what is known from what is assumed** — Three columns: confirmed, suspected, unknown. Confirmed — jars are cracking and a thread is growing. Suspected — a single bad batch. Unknown — how many units, and whether it is supplier fault or Nimbus QC. You may only speak publicly to column one.
3. **Resolve the silence question** — Debate whether saying nothing until Operations confirms everything is safer. It is not: a vacuum gets filled by the thread, and by morning the story is written without Nimbus in it. Acknowledging without concluding is the professional move.
4. **Draft tonight's holding statement** — Write what Nimbus posts within hours. It must acknowledge, show the issue is being taken seriously, state what is being done now, and say when the next update comes — without admitting a cause nobody has confirmed. Say what is true, say what you are doing, say when you will say more.
5. **Prepare the Spokesperson's honest commitments** — List what can be committed to before root cause is known: investigating, replacing affected units, updating by a stated time. These are process commitments, which are always available; cause commitments are not.
6. **Run the interview** — The Journalist asks directly whether Nimbus knew about a defect before launch. The Spokesperson must answer honestly without speculating. Watch for the two failure modes: over-promising a cause not yet confirmed, and stonewalling into a 'no comment' that reads as guilt.
7. **Keep internal and external in sync** — Define how the Crisis-Response Lead and Spokesperson stay aligned — one shared fact-sheet, updated at a fixed cadence, from which all public statements are drawn. Crises are usually made worse by two people saying different true things.
8. **Benchmark against a real example** — Compare your plan against a real 2024-25 brand crisis. Decide whether yours resembles the fast-and-transparent response or the delayed-and-silent one, and name which specific choice in your plan puts it in that category.
9. **Write the 24-hour commitment** — State the follow-up Nimbus commits to publicly within 24 hours, and who owns it.

## Your working space

Complete every field. You may keep this worksheet and refer to it during the open-book assessment.

### Step 1 — Assign the three roles

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### Step 2 — Separate what is known from what is assumed

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### Step 3 — Resolve the silence question

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**Step 4 — Draft tonight's holding statement**

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**Step 5 — Prepare the Spokesperson's honest commitments**

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**Step 6 — Run the interview**

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**Step 7 — Keep internal and external in sync**

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**Step 8 — Benchmark against a real example**

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**Step 9 — Write the 24-hour commitment**

## Answers to the discussion prompts

**1. Is staying silent until Operations confirms every fact actually the safer choice tonight, or does it leave a vacuum the thread will fill for Nimbus?**

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**2. What can the Spokesperson honestly commit to in tomorrow's interview before the root cause is even confirmed?**

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**3. How should the Crisis-Response Lead's internal fact-finding and the Spokesperson's public statement stay in sync without one getting ahead of the other?**

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**4. What would Nimbus need to say and do in the first 24 hours to be judged as fast and transparent rather than defensive?**

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## Reflect & discuss

**Did your Spokesperson end up promising more, or less, than Nimbus could actually deliver by morning?**

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**Where did the Journalist's questions expose a gap between what the Crisis-Response Lead knew and what the Spokesperson said?**

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**Looking at the Cracker Barrel and McDonald's examples, which pattern did your group's response end up closer to — and was that a deliberate choice?**

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### **Check your work**

Every group can perform or narrate a same-night response that names what Nimbus confirms publicly within hours, what it says in tomorrow's interview, and a follow-up commitment — and can point to which real-world example (fast/transparent vs delayed/silent) their plan resembles.